UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART II: OBTAINING AND RETAINING WORK

TOPIC 8: JOB ADVANCEMENT

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand qualities and characteristics that help people advance at work
- Understand how different strategies work for different situations
- Understand the importance of being able to deal effectively with change

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Identify their personal qualities and characteristics that will help them advance
- Identify something that they want to learn that they believe will help them advance at work

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students will think about the importance of continuous learning for job advancement.

Time: 10 minutes

Ask the group to consider individually: What did you learn yesterday? After giving students one minute to think about it, ask them to share. (If someone cannot think of something he/she learned yesterday — ask them to think of the most recent thing he/she has learned).

Discussion Questions:

- If you can't think of anything you learned yesterday, how far back do you need to go to find something?
- Was it learning for work, or life, or both — and what's the difference anyway?
- How did you learn it?
- How could you measure/quantify/apply it?
- How might you transfer it/teach it to someone else?
- What will change now that you've learned it?
- What further learning does it prompt or enable?
- How is learning related to job advancement?
- What can you do to try to learn something new everyday?

Have all students identify three things that they want to learn in the next month that they believe will help them advance at work.

Group Debate: Early Bird/Second Mouse

Objective: Students will understand how different strategies work for different situations.
Time: 15-20 minutes
Materials: Flipchart, markers, other presentation materials

The activity is based on the funny one-liner (often attributed to comedian Stephen Wright), which is deeper than first seems: "The early bird may get the worm, but the second mouse gets the cheese."

Split the group into two teams. Nominate one team to be *'early bird'* and the other team to be *'second mouse'.* Give the teams 5-10 minutes each to develop a 60-second presentation as to why their strategy ('early bird' or 'second mouse') is best for work (or life). Teams may use flipchart, markers or other available materials for their presentation, but they do not have to use anything.

Encourage the teams to make use of the knowledge and abilities and views of **all** team members in creating their presentations.

After the two presentations, chair a 5-10 minute debate between the teams around the question: "Early bird or second mouse: Which is the most effective strategy for work (or life)?"

At the end of the debate, discuss the advantages and disadvantages of both strategies. Ask students why it is important to be able to choose an appropriate strategy for various situations they may face. How would this relate to job advancement? (Often times with job advancement, you will be given additional responsibilities and employers want to know you will be able to effectively handle the challenges that will come with those additional responsibilities). What else can you learn from this exercise?

Adapted from http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm

Small Group Activity

Objective: Students will understand ways to advance at work.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Handout: "Candidate Descriptions," flipchart paper and markers

Divide students into small groups (4-5 students). Explain the situation. You have just taken over the family business from your mother who is retiring. You need someone to help you run the business as your right-hand man/woman. You want to promote from within the company, and you have narrowed the search down to two top candidates. Before handing out the descriptions of the two candidates, give the small groups five minutes to create a list of the most important characteristics/qualities that they would look for in choosing the candidate. At the end of the five minutes, hand out the "Candidate Descriptions." The small groups need to discuss the strengths and weaknesses of each candidate and agree on who should get the job and why. The small groups also need to create a training plan to identify the most important areas for the candidate to work on right away.

Greg has been working for the company for 20 years. He has the most experience and he knows about all of the different components of the business. Greg is extremely well organized, but he is shy and does not always communicate well with other employees. He would rather work behind the scenes. Greg meets every deadline and his work is impeccable. If he is not able to stay late to finish a project, he will take work home. Greg would never make an important decision without checking in, even though you trust his judgment and have told him that he can make certain decisions on his own. Greg is always consistent and fair in how he treats people — customers and employees. Plus he knows all about the different areas of the company.

Angela has been working for the company for about 7 years. She is an extremely positive and friendly person with excellent interpersonal skills. The customers love her and other employees want to work with her. Angela is not afraid to make an important decision; at times, she works by the philosophy "It is easier to ask for forgiveness than it is to ask for permission." You wish she would check in before making certain decisions. Angela is creative and resourceful, but she does not always meet deadlines and sometimes you are not sure what she will do next. Although she does not know all of the different components of the business, she is a very quick learner.

Ask the small groups to present their choice as well as their reasons to the larger group. Have the small groups also share which qualities and characteristics they identified prior to reading the candidate descriptions and how much their list influenced their final decision. Discuss as a large group what characteristics are most beneficial in helping people advance at work.

Large Group Reading/Discussion

If you have access to the internet, ask students to go to one of the following sites and read the article:

- http://msn.careerbuilder.com/Article/MSN-2227-Career-Growth-and-Change-The-11-Keys-to-Success/?cbsid=76d9d608d7d04202b88f41d5fe56d799-324900889-x7-6&sc_extcmp=JS_2227_advice&cbRecursionCnt=2&SiteId=cbmsn42227&ArticleID=2227&gt1=23000
  "The 11 Keys to Success"
- http://www.allbusiness.com/human-resources/careers-career-development/11128-1.html
  "Ten Tips on Career Advancement"
- http://www.entrepreneurismbible.com/career/kb_career-top-10-tips-for-career-advancement.htm
  "Top 10 Tips for Career Advancement"

Discuss the article(s) and compare the tips for career advancement with the lists the small groups created, as well as their reasons for choosing Greg or Angela. Where was their overlap? What new things did the article introduce to the discussion. After reading the article, ask students if they would change their choice. Why or why not?

At the end of the discussion, ask students to identify five character strengths and personal qualities that will help them advance at work.

Kinesthetic Activity: Change Exercise

Objective: Students will understand the importance of being able to deal effectively with change.
Time: 10-30 minutes
Materials: Scissors, paper, garbage can, calculators, pens/pencils, toothpicks and mini marshmallows

Here are some simple quick ideas to help demonstrate the brain's reaction to change. They are based on having to accomplish a simple everyday task in a different way:

Tasks:

1. Write the alphabet with your opposite hand (if right-handed, use your left hand; if left-handed, use your right hand)
2. Cut paper shapes in pairs (with each person holding one handle of the scissors)
3. Shoot paper balls into a garbage can with your eyes closed (from your seat or other designated spot)
4. Turn a calculator upside down to figure out some math problems OR turn a keyboard upside down and type something
5. Build a marshmallow/toothpick structure as a team, with each person only being able to use one hand

Discussion Questions/Learning Points:

- Which challenge was most difficult for you? Why?
  Which challenge was the most fun? Why?
- How did you respond to the different challenges? Did you want to keep trying until you could do the task well? Did you want to give up? Did you want to go back to doing things they way you were used to?
- How do these responses connect to job advancement? When you advance at work, you will face changes — changes in responsibilities, changes in tasks, changes in your professional relationships with other employees, etc. How can you prepare for these changes?
- Different types of change create different pressures — on different parts of the brain — and these effects vary according to the individual. It does not matter that the methods are mostly ridiculous — the point is to demonstrate and experience the different pressures of different types of change.
- Observe and review how different people react in different ways to different methods. We do not react to change in the same ways. Empathy for other people's feelings is therefore crucial in managing change affecting other people.
- Change of any sort is difficult ultimately when:
  - change requires the brain to overcome fear (of failure and self-doubt, etc.) and uncertainty of the change itself (which can be extreme for certain people/personalities)
  - change requires the brain (and often the body too) to learn something new, or to re-learn or accept something in a different way
- Change can be especially frustrating if it involves re-learning something which, under a previous method or system, was achievable competently — because the brain can imagine and remember being competent, which can cause a sense of loss or failure relative to past experience.

Adapted from http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm#team-building-games-exercises-activities

Job Advancement

Three things I want to learn that will help me advance at work:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Character strengths and personal qualities that will help me advance at work:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

Candidate Descriptions

Candidate One

Greg has been working for the company for 20 years. He has the most experience and he knows about all of the different components of the business. Greg is extremely well organized, but he is shy and does not always communicate well with other employees. He would rather work behind the scenes. Greg meets every deadline and his work is impeccable. If he is not able to stay late to finish a project, he will take work home. Greg would never make an important decision without checking in, even though you trust his judgment and have told him that he can make certain decisions on his own. Greg is always consistent and fair in how he treats people — customers and employees. Plus he knows all about the different areas of the company.

Strengths: _____

Weaknesses: _____

Training Plan: _____

Candidate Two

Angela has been working for the company for about 7 years. She is an extremely positive and friendly person with excellent interpersonal skills. The customers love her and other employees want to work with her. Angela is not afraid to make an important decision; at times, she works by the philosophy "It is easier to ask for forgiveness than it is to ask for permission." You wish she would check in before making certain decisions. Angela is creative and resourceful, but she does not always meet deadlines and sometimes you are not sure what she will do next. Although she does not know all of the different components of the business, she is a very quick learner.

Strengths: _____

Weaknesses: _____

Training Plan: _____

Small Group's Choice: _____